
A PERSONAL MASTER COURSE FOR ICSE

JULIUS CAESAR

Act 3 — ICSE Board Guide

The compact board guide to Act 3: the assassination, the two funeral speeches, characters, themes, devices, twenty quotations, and two full practice sets with model answers

Prepared for an ICSE Class 10 student · Based on the verified Shakespeare text (Folger / Globe editions) · Cross-checked against Plutarch and modern Roman history · Aligned to the CISCE Literature in English paper

Act 1 is the Class IX portion of the syllabus; the Class X board paper (Acts III–V) depends on it at every turn. This book teaches Act 1 from zero to examination standard.

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FRONT MATTER

Act 3 for the ICSE Board: The Assassination and the Funeral

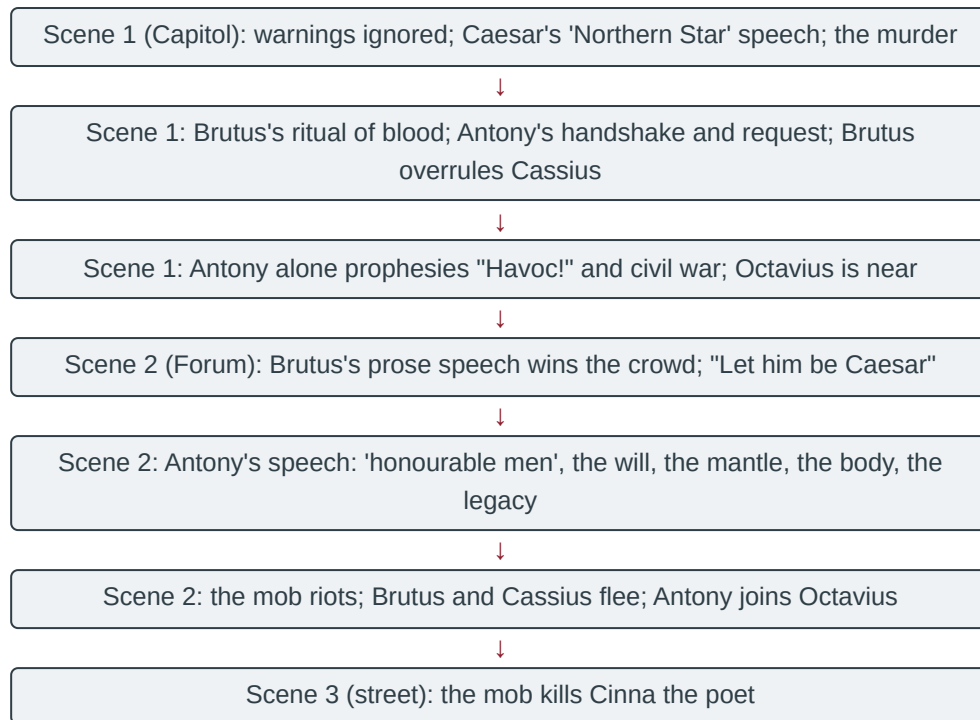
What this chapter does: Act 3 is the heart of the Class X board portion of Julius Caesar. This compact guide teaches all three scenes, the two funeral speeches side by side, the characters, themes and devices, twenty quotations, the words that trip students, and exactly how to answer the board's extract questions, with two full practice sets and model answers. Every quotation has been checked against the Folger and Globe texts.

ICSE EXAM BOX How Act 3 is examined

For the ICSE Class X Literature in English paper, the drama section (Julius Caesar, Acts III–V) is tested through extract-based questions worth 16 marks each, with five sub-questions. In the 2025 paper these were marked [3][3][3][3][4], and one of the two drama extracts was Antony's "Friends, Romans, countrymen" speech from Act 3 Scene 2. The compulsory multiple-choice Section A also drew on Act 3 ('thou bleeding piece of earth', 'ambition's debt is paid', Cinna the poet). Act 3 is therefore the single most valuable act to know thoroughly. No specific question is guaranteed.

Act 3 in one minute

The Ides of March. Caesar brushes aside the Soothsayer and Artemidorus, refuses to recall Metellus Cimber's banished brother, declares himself "constant as the Northern Star", and is stabbed by the conspirators; Casca strikes first, Brutus last: "Et tu, Brutè?" Brutus has the conspirators bathe their hands in Caesar's blood as a ritual of liberty. Antony sends a servant, comes in person, shakes the bloody hands, and asks only to speak at the funeral. Brutus agrees against Cassius's advice. Alone, Antony prophesies civil war. In the Forum, Brutus's reasoned prose speech wins the crowd; Antony's verse speech, using repetition, Caesar's wounds and Caesar's will, turns the same crowd into a mob that burns the conspirators' houses. Octavius has reached Rome; Brutus and Cassius flee. In the street, the mob tears Cinna the poet to pieces for sharing a conspirator's name.



The people of Act 3

Character	What they do in Act 3	The point to remember
Caesar	Ignores every warning; refuses Cimber's plea; is killed	His last speeches are his most self-glorifying, which makes the fall sharper
Brutus	Strikes last; leads the blood ritual; spares Antony and lets him speak; wins the crowd then loses it	Honourable, reasonable, and politically blind
Cassius	Fears discovery; warns against Antony speaking; is overruled twice	Right about Antony, wrong about his own authority over Brutus
Antony	Flees, returns, shakes hands, asks to speak; prophesies; wins Rome	The reveller of Act 1 proves a master politician
Casca	Strikes the first blow ("Speak, hands, for me!")	The blunt cynic becomes the first murderer
Decius, Cinna, Metellus Cimber, Trebonius	Play their parts: Trebonius draws Antony away, Metellus kneels, Cinna proclaims liberty	A plot executed exactly as planned, and still a disaster
Popilius Lena	Wishes the conspirators luck, then speaks to Caesar	The scare that shows how fragile the plot is
Artemidorus and the Soothsayer	Final warnings	"The ides of March are come." "Ay, Caesar, but not gone."
The Plebeians	Cheer Brutus, then Antony, then riot	The fickle crowd of Act 1 Scene 1 becomes a weapon
Cinna the poet	Killed for his name	Mob violence has no reason
Octavius (reported) and Lepidus	Arrive in Rome	The next power is already forming

Scene 1 — The Capitol

What happens

1. Caesar meets the Soothsayer ("The ides of March are come" / "Ay, Caesar, but not gone") and refuses Artemidorus's letter because it "touches Caesar nearer": "What touches us ourself shall be last served."
2. Popilius Lena wishes the conspirators well, and Cassius panics; Brutus steadies him. Trebonius leads Antony away.
3. Metellus Cimber kneels to beg for his banished brother. Caesar rejects "sweet words, / Low-crookèd curtsies, and base spaniel fawning". Brutus and Cassius kneel too. Caesar compares himself to the Northern Star, the one fixed point in the sky.
4. Casca strikes first; the others follow; Brutus last. Caesar: "Et tu, Brutè?—Then fall, Caesar."
5. Cinna and Cassius cry "Liberty! Freedom! Tyranny is dead!" Brutus calms the senators: "Ambition's debt is paid." Antony has fled.
6. Brutus makes the conspirators bathe their hands and swords in Caesar's blood and walk to the marketplace crying "Peace, freedom, and liberty!" Cassius imagines the scene re-enacted "In states unborn and accents yet unknown".
7. Antony's servant kneels with a careful message. Brutus promises Antony safety "by my honour".
8. Antony enters, mourns over the body, offers himself for death, then shakes each bloody hand. He asks to speak at the funeral. Cassius objects privately; Brutus insists he will speak first and that Antony must not blame the conspirators.
9. Alone with the body, Antony prophesies "Domestic fury and fierce civil strife" and Caesar's spirit crying "Havoc!" Octavius's servant arrives; Octavius is seven leagues from Rome.

The hard lines, made simple

Caesar: *I could be well moved, if I were as you. / If I could pray to move, prayers would move me. / But I am constant as the Northern Star, / Of whose true fixed and resting quality / There is no fellow in the firmament.*

Simple English: If I were like you I could be swayed; if I begged others, their begging would move me. But I am as unchanging as the Pole Star, the one star that never moves. **Difficult words:** constant = unchanging; fellow = equal; firmament = sky. **Why it matters:** Caesar claims a godlike fixity moments before he is killed. He goes on: of all men "I do know but one / That unassailable holds on his rank, / Unshaked of motion; and that I am he". Then "Wilt thou lift up Olympus?" and "Doth not Brutus bootless kneel?" (bootless = uselessly). **LITERARY INTERPRETATION:** the speech is usually read as hubris, the pride that invites a fall, but it is also a refusal to govern by favouritism. An excellent answer notes both.

Casca: *Speak, hands, for me!* **Caesar:** *Et tu, Brutè?—Then fall, Caesar.*

Simple English: Casca: let my hands speak instead of words. Caesar: You too, Brutus? Then Caesar will fall. **Why it matters:** The Latin (and you, Brutus?) marks the one wound that breaks Caesar's will. **HISTORICAL RECORD:** the Latin phrase is not in Plutarch; Shakespeare took it from earlier English tradition. Antony will later call Brutus's stab "the most unkindest cut of all".

Brutus: *Stoop, Romans, stoop, / And let us bathe our hands in Caesar's blood / Up to the elbows and besmear our swords.*

Simple English: Bend down, Romans, and cover our hands and swords in Caesar's blood. **Why it matters:**

This is Brutus's "sacrificers, but not butchers" idea from Act 2 made visible: he wants the murder to look like a sacred rite. The dramatic irony is that it fulfils Calpurnia's dream exactly ("many lusty Romans / Came smiling and did bathe their hands in it"), and that it hands Antony his most powerful image.

Cassius: *How many ages hence / Shall this our lofty scene be acted over / In states unborn and accents yet unknown!*

Simple English: How many centuries from now will this great scene be performed again, in countries that do not yet exist and languages not yet spoken! **Why it matters:** Shakespeare's audience was itself the fulfilment of the line. The conspirators think they are writing history as liberators; the play will show Antony rewriting it.

Antony: *O mighty Caesar, dost thou lie so low? / Are all thy conquests, glories, triumphs, spoils / Shrunk to this little measure?*

Simple English: Great Caesar, is this how you end? Have all your victories shrunk to the size of a corpse?

Why it matters: Antony speaks to the body before he speaks to the killers. His grief is real, and it is also his first move: he offers his own life ("Fulfil your pleasure") so that Brutus must reassure him.

Brutus: *Our hearts you see not; they are pitiful; / And pity to the general wrong of Rome / (As fire drives out fire, so pity pity) / Hath done this deed on Caesar.*

Simple English: You cannot see our hearts, which are full of pity; pity for Rome's suffering drove out pity for Caesar, as one fire drives out another. **Why it matters:** Brutus keeps explaining motives to a man who is counting daggers.

Antony: *Let each man render me his bloody hand.*

Simple English: Let every one of you shake my hand with the blood still on it. **Why it matters:** Antony names each conspirator as he takes each hand; he will name them again from the pulpit when he shows the wounds in the mantle. Then he turns to the corpse: "Pardon me, Julius! Here wast thou bayed, brave hart" (bayed = cornered by hounds; hart = stag, with a pun on heart). The hunters "stand / Signed in thy spoil and crimsoned in thy Lethe" (marked with your blood; Lethe = the river of death).

Cassius: *You know not what you do. Do not consent / That Antony speak in his funeral.* **Cassius:** *Know you how much the people may be moved / By that which he will utter?*

Simple English: You do not realise what you are doing. Do not let Antony speak; you cannot imagine how he could move the crowd. **Why it matters:** The decisive error. Brutus answers that he will speak first and Antony will speak "by leave and by permission", and that it "shall advantage more than do us wrong." Cassius: "I know not what may fall. I like it not."

Antony: *O pardon me, thou bleeding piece of earth, / That I am meek and gentle with these butchers.*

Simple English: Forgive me, Caesar's bleeding body, for being so mild with these slaughterers. **Why it**

matters: The soliloquy reveals the real Antony. He uses Brutus's own rejected word, "butchers". He prophesies that Caesar's wounds, "like dumb mouths", will demand revenge; that "Domestic fury and fierce civil strife / Shall cumber all the parts of Italy"; and that "Caesar's spirit, ranging for revenge, / With Ate by his side come hot from hell, / Shall...Cry 'Havoc!' and let slip the dogs of war." Ate = the Greek goddess of ruin; "Havoc!" = the military order to kill without mercy; cumber = burden.

PROFESSOR'S INSIGHT Why Shakespeare gives Caesar his proudest speech last

Caesar speaks more arrogantly in Scene 1 than anywhere else: he is the Northern Star, Olympus, the one unmoving man. Shakespeare does this for two reasons. First, so that the murder can look, for a moment, justified: the conspirators kneel and are kicked "like a cur". Second, so that the fall is total: within forty lines the fixed star lies "No worthier than the dust". The scene does not tell you whether the killing was right. It shows you a man at his most godlike and then shows you the body, and leaves the judgement to the Forum.

Scene 2 — The Forum: two speeches

What happens

1. The plebeians demand reasons. Brutus sends Cassius to speak to half the crowd elsewhere and mounts the pulpit.
2. Brutus speaks in prose: he loved Caesar, but loved Rome more; Caesar was ambitious; would they rather be slaves? The crowd is won: "Live, Brutus, live, live!" and, disastrously, "Let him be Caesar."
3. Brutus asks them to stay and hear Antony, then leaves alone. Nobody from the conspiracy stays to watch.
4. Antony speaks in verse. He praises Brutus as "an honourable man" again and again while producing evidence that Caesar was not ambitious: the ransoms, the tears for the poor, the thrice-refused crown. He pauses to weep; the crowd begins to turn.
5. He mentions a will he will not read. The crowd demands it. He descends, shows Caesar's torn mantle, names the stabs ("the most unkindest cut of all"), then uncovers the body.
6. The crowd cries revenge. Antony holds them back ("I am no orator, as Brutus is") and then releases them with the will: seventy-five drachmas each and Caesar's gardens for the people. They go to burn the conspirators' houses.
7. Alone: "Now let it work. Mischief, thou art afoot". Octavius and Lepidus are at Caesar's house; Brutus and Cassius have fled Rome.

Brutus's speech, line by line

Brutus: *Romans, countrymen, and lovers, hear me for my cause, and be silent that you may hear. Believe me for mine honour, and have respect to mine honour that you may believe.*

Simple English: Fellow Romans, friends, listen to my reasons. Trust me because I am honourable. **Notice:** prose, not verse; balanced, mirrored clauses (hear/believe, honour/believe). He asks to be believed on his reputation. **Device:** antithesis and chiasmus (a mirrored phrase).

Brutus: *not that I loved Caesar less, but that I loved Rome more.*

The core of his case: love for Rome outweighed love for a friend. Then the great question: "Had you rather Caesar were living, and die all slaves, than that Caesar were dead, to live all freemen?"

Brutus: *As Caesar loved me, I weep for him. As he was fortunate, I rejoice at it. As he was valiant, I honour him. But, as he was ambitious, I slew him.*

Device: parallel structure in four clauses, then summed up: "There is tears for his love, joy for his fortune, honour for his valour, and death for his ambition." The word *ambitious* is asserted, never proved. Antony will attack exactly this gap.

Brutus: *Who is here so base that would be a bondman? If any, speak, for him have I offended.*

Device: rhetorical questions in a series (base/bondman, rude/not a Roman, vile/not love his country). Each makes disagreement shameful. "I pause for a reply." The crowd: "None, Brutus, none."

Brutus: *as I slew my best lover for the good of Rome, I have the same dagger for myself when it shall please my country to need my death.*

Simple English: I killed my dearest friend for Rome, and will kill myself if Rome ever needs it. **Why it matters:** Noble, and sincere; Act 5 will keep the promise. But the crowd's response, "Let him be Caesar", shows they have understood nothing about the Republic. They want a new master.

Antony's speech, line by line

Antony: *Friends, Romans, countrymen, lend me your ears. / I come to bury Caesar, not to praise him. / The evil that men do lives after them; / The good is oft interrèd with their bones.*

Simple English: Listen to me. I am here to bury Caesar, not to flatter him. People remember a man's faults and forget his virtues. **Notice:** he starts with "Friends", where Brutus started with "Romans". He claims he will not praise, then does nothing else. "Lend me your ears" asks for a loan, not obedience.

Antony: *The noble Brutus / Hath told you Caesar was ambitious. / If it were so, it was a grievous fault, / And grievously hath Caesar answered it.*

Notice the "If". Antony never contradicts Brutus directly. He repeats Brutus's word and lets the evidence undermine it.

Antony: *For Brutus is an honourable man; / So are they all, all honourable men*

Device: repetition that becomes verbal irony. The phrase recurs after each piece of evidence ("He hath brought many captives home to Rome..."; "When that the poor have cried, Caesar hath wept; / Ambition should be made of sterner stuff"; "I thrice presented him a kingly crown, / Which he did thrice refuse. Was this ambition?"). By the fourth repetition the crowd hears the opposite of the words. Note the small shift to "And sure he is an honourable man."

Antony: *You all did love him once, not without cause. / What cause withholds you, then, to mourn for him?*

Device: rhetorical question, answered by the next line's attack on the crowd's judgement: "O judgement, thou art fled to brutish beasts, / And men have lost their reason!" Then the pause: "My heart is in the coffin there with Caesar, / And I must pause till it come back to me." The pause lets the plebeians talk themselves round ("Caesar has had great wrong"; "There's not a nobler man in Rome than Antony").

Antony: *But here's a parchment with the seal of Caesar. / I found it in his closet. 'Tis his will. / Let but the commons hear this testament, / Which, pardon me, I do not mean to read*

Device: paralipsis, mentioning what you claim you will not mention. Then: "You are not wood, you are not stones, but men" (an echo, deliberate or not, of Marullus's "You blocks, you stones" in Act 1 Scene 1). "'Tis good you know not that you are his heirs". He makes them beg.

Antony: *You all do know this mantle. I remember / The first time ever Caesar put it on. / 'Twas on a summer's evening in his tent, / That day he overcame the Nervii.*

Simple English: You know this cloak. I remember when he first wore it, the evening he beat the Nervii (a Gallic tribe). **Why it matters:** The personal memory makes the cloak a relic. Antony then reads the stabs in the cloth as if he had been there (he had not): "Look, in this place ran Cassius' dagger through. / See what a rent the envious Casca made. / Through this the well-belovèd Brutus stabbed". The blood "rushing out of doors" to see "If Brutus so unkindly knocked or no" is a conceit: the blood itself cannot believe Brutus did it.

Antony: *For Brutus, as you know, was Caesar's angel. / Judge, O you gods, how dearly Caesar loved him! / This was the most unkindest cut of all.*

Simple English: Brutus was Caesar's dearest friend; the gods know how Caesar loved him; so his was the cruellest wound. **Notice:** the double superlative ("most unkindest") is deliberate intensity. "Ingratitude, more strong than traitors' arms, / Quite vanquished him." The word "traitors" has now arrived, unopposed. Caesar fell "Even at the base of Pompey's statue / (Which all the while ran blood)".

Antony: *Kind souls, what, weep you when you but behold / Our Caesar's vesture wounded? Look you here, / Here is himself, marred as you see with traitors.*

The climax: he lifts the cloak from the body. The crowd: "Revenge! About! Seek! Burn! Fire! Kill! / Slay! Let not a traitor live!"

Antony: *I am no orator, as Brutus is, / But, as you know me all, a plain blunt man / That love my friend*

Device: false modesty. He has just delivered the greatest oration in the play. "For I have neither wit, nor words, nor worth, / Action, nor utterance, nor the power of speech / To stir men's blood. I only speak right on." Then the counterfactual: "were I Brutus, / And Brutus Antony, there were an Antony / Would ruffle up your spirits and put a tongue / In every wound of Caesar that should move / The stones of Rome to rise and mutiny."

Antony: *To every Roman citizen he gives, / To every several man, seventy-five drachmas.*

The will at last: money, and then "all his walks, / His private arbours, and new-planted orchards, / On this side Tiber". "Here was a Caesar! When comes such another?" The crowd: "Never, never!" They go to burn.

Antony: *Now let it work. Mischief, thou art afoot; / Take thou what course thou wilt.*

Simple English: Let it happen now. Trouble is on the move; go where you like. **Why it matters:** The mask drops. Compare his earlier "let me not stir you up / To such a sudden flood of mutiny." Antony has done precisely what he said he would not.

Brutus versus Antony: the comparison the examiner wants

	Brutus	Antony
Form	Prose: measured, balanced, logical	Blank verse: flowing, emotional, dramatic

	Brutus	Antony
Opening word	"Romans" (duty first)	"Friends" (feeling first)
Basis of appeal	His own honour; reason; the public good	Evidence, memory, pity, greed; Caesar's body and will
Method	Antithesis, parallel clauses, rhetorical questions; asserts Caesar was "ambitious"	Repetition with irony ("honourable man"), rhetorical questions, pauses, props (mantle, body, will), false modesty
Attitude to the crowd	Asks them to judge "in your wisdom"	Plays on them as "men", not "wood" or "stones"; makes them beg
Treatment of opponent	Praises Antony, lets him speak	Never attacks Brutus directly; lets the word "honourable" rot
Fatal gap	Never proves ambition; leaves before Antony speaks	None; he adjusts to every reaction
Result	"Let him be Caesar" (they miss the point)	"Let not a traitor live!" (they do exactly what he wants)

PROFESSOR'S INSIGHT Brutus loses in the moment he wins

"Let him be Caesar" is the most frightening line in the scene, and it is spoken in Brutus's praise. The crowd has just heard a speech about freedom from one-man rule and responded by offering one-man rule to the speaker. Shakespeare shows that Brutus's argument never reached them; his honour did, and honour is transferable to whoever speaks next. When Brutus walks away "alone", he leaves the stage to a man who understands that the crowd wants a Caesar, and gives them a dead one to love.

Scene 3 — Cinna the poet

Cinna the poet, troubled by a dream that he "did feast with Caesar", walks out and meets the mob. They interrogate him with four questions at once. When he gives his name, they cry "Tear him to pieces! He's a conspirator." He protests, "I am Cinna the poet", and they answer, "Tear him for his bad verses". "It is no matter. His name's Cinna. / Pluck but his name out of his heart". They kill him and run to burn the conspirators' houses.

Why the scene exists: it is the first fruit of Antony's "Mischief"; it shows mob violence as pure, reasonless appetite; it echoes Act 1 Scene 1, where the tribunes could at least shame the crowd into silence; and it rhymes grimly with Cassius's claim in Scene 1 that they would be remembered as "The men that gave their country liberty". This is what liberty looks like in the street. **HISTORICAL RECORD:** Plutarch tells the story of the poet Helvius Cinna being killed in mistake for the praetor Cornelius Cinna.

Themes of Act 3 in brief

Theme	Where you see it	One line to use
Rhetoric and persuasion	The two funeral speeches	Reason wins a hearing; emotion wins a city
Public opinion and the mob	"Live, Brutus"; "Let not a traitor live!"; Cinna the poet	The crowd is a weapon that belongs to whoever holds it last
Honour versus political judgement	Brutus's "by my honour"; letting Antony speak	Brutus's virtue is the conspiracy's blind spot

Theme	Where you see it	One line to use
Appearance and reality	Antony's handshake; "I am no orator"; "honourable men"	Antony performs loyalty to the killers and loyalty to Caesar in the same hour
Pride and fate	"constant as the Northern Star"; "The ides of March are come"	Caesar's certainty is his vulnerability
Betrayal and friendship	"Et tu, Brutè?"; "the most unkindest cut of all"	The wound that kills is the one from a friend
Violence and its consequences	Blood ritual; "Havoc!"; the riot	A killing meant as a sacrifice becomes a civil war
Ambition	Brutus's charge; Antony's three refutations	The word that justifies the murder cannot survive examination

Devices to name

Device	Example	Effect
Dramatic irony	"The ides of March are come." / "Ay, Caesar, but not gone."	Audience knows what Caesar does not
Hubris (pride)	"constant as the Northern Star"	Sets up the fall
Metaphor and conceit	Caesar's blood "rushing out of doors to be resolved / If Brutus so unkindly knocked"	Makes the blood a witness against Brutus
Verbal irony through repetition	"Brutus is an honourable man"	The words come to mean their opposite
Rhetorical question	"Had you rather Caesar were living, and die all slaves...?"	Forces the listener to the speaker's answer
Antithesis and parallelism	"not that I loved Caesar less, but that I loved Rome more"	Clarity and balance; sounds reasonable
Paralipsis	"Which, pardon me, I do not mean to read"	Raises desire by withholding
Personification	"O judgement, thou art fled to brutish beasts"; "Mischief, thou art afoot"	Abstractions become actors
Apostrophe	"O pardon me, thou bleeding piece of earth"	Direct address to the dead
Imagery of hunting	"Here wast thou bayed, brave hart"	Caesar as the noble stag; the conspirators as hounds
Prose versus verse	Brutus speaks prose; Antony speaks verse	Reason versus passion, made audible
Prophecy	"Cry 'Havoc!' and let slip the dogs of war"	Foretells Acts 4 and 5

Twenty quotations to know

Speaker	Quotation	Use it for
Caesar / Soothsayer	"The ides of March are come." / "Ay, Caesar, but not gone."	Dramatic irony; fate
Caesar	"What touches us ourself shall be last served."	The public pose that costs his life

Speaker	Quotation	Use it for
Caesar	"I am constant as the Northern Star"	Pride; the fixed star before the fall
Caesar	"Wilt thou lift up Olympus?"	Caesar as a god
Casca	"Speak, hands, for me!"	The first blow
Caesar	"Et tu, Brutè?—Then fall, Caesar."	Betrayal by a friend
Brutus	"Ambition's debt is paid."	The conspirators' justification
Brutus	"let us bathe our hands in Caesar's blood"	Ritual; Calpurnia's dream fulfilled
Cassius	"In states unborn and accents yet unknown!"	History and theatre
Antony	"O mighty Caesar, dost thou lie so low?"	Antony's grief
Antony	"Let each man render me his bloody hand."	Appearance and reality
Antony	"Pardon me, Julius! Here wast thou bayed, brave hart"	Hunting imagery
Cassius	"Know you how much the people may be moved / By that which he will utter?"	Cassius's correct fear
Antony	"O pardon me, thou bleeding piece of earth"	The soliloquy; the real Antony
Antony	"Cry 'Havoc!' and let slip the dogs of war"	Prophecy of civil war
Brutus	"not that I loved Caesar less, but that I loved Rome more."	Brutus's case
Plebeian	"Let him be Caesar."	The crowd misses the point
Antony	"Friends, Romans, countrymen, lend me your ears."	The opening of the great speech
Antony	"This was the most unkindest cut of all."	Brutus's betrayal as Antony frames it
Antony	"Now let it work. Mischief, thou art afoot"	The mask drops

Words that trip students

Word	Meaning here
schedule	document, paper
suit	petition, request
puissant	powerful
couchings	bowings
preordinance and first decree	laws settled long ago
fond	foolish
spaniel fawning	dog-like flattery
cur	mongrel dog
enfranchisement	freedom (from banishment)
apprehensive	capable of reason
bootless	uselessly

Word	Meaning here
pulpits	public speaking platforms
abide	pay the penalty for
amazed	stunned
abridged	shortened
vouchsafe	grant
resolved	given a full explanation
purpled	blood-stained
rank	diseased; due for bleeding
leaden points	blunt (harmless) swords
bayed	cornered (like a hunted animal)
hart	male deer (pun on heart)
Lethe	river of the underworld; here, Caesar's life-blood
cumber	burden, trouble
Ate	goddess of ruin and discord
Havoc	the command to slaughter without restraint
carrion	rotting flesh
lovers	friends (not romantic)
censure	judge
bondman	slave
rude	uncivilised
enrolled	recorded
extenuated	understated
beholding	indebted
coffers	treasury
sterner stuff	harder material
closet	private room
napkins	handkerchiefs
o'ershot myself	gone further than I meant
mantle	cloak
Nervii	a Gallic tribe Caesar defeated
rent	tear
dint	force, impression
vesture	clothing
drachmas	Greek silver coins (Shakespeare's anachronism)
arbours	shaded garden walks

Word	Meaning here
forms	benches

Connections: how Act 3 pays off Acts 1 and 2

Earlier	Act 3
Soothsayer: "Beware the ides of March" (Act 1 Scene 2)	"The ides of March are come." / "Ay, Caesar, but not gone."
Caesar on Cassius: "I rather tell thee what is to be feared / Than what I fear"	"What touches us ourself shall be last served"; the Northern Star
Cassius: Antony should "fall together" with Caesar (Act 2 Scene 1)	Antony lives, speaks, and destroys them
Brutus: "sacrificers, but not butchers" (Act 2 Scene 1)	The blood ritual; Antony calls them "butchers"
Calpurnia's dream of Romans bathing hands in blood (Act 2 Scene 2)	"let us bathe our hands in Caesar's blood"
Decius: Caesar "loves to hear" flattery	Caesar: "Low-crookèd curtsies, and base spaniel fawning"
Marullus: "You blocks, you stones" (Act 1 Scene 1)	Antony: "You are not wood, you are not stones, but men"
Casca's report: the crown "thrice" refused (Act 1 Scene 2)	Antony: "I thrice presented him a kingly crown, / Which he did thrice refuse."
Casca: Caesar "sits high in all the people's hearts" (Act 1 Scene 3)	The will proves it; the crowd avenges him
The fickle crowd of Act 1 Scene 1	The crowd turns twice in one scene
Act 1's two Cinna's	Cinna the poet dies for the conspirator's name

How the board marks an Act 3 answer

ICSE EXAM BOX The shape of a 16-mark extract question

The extract is 10–14 lines. Five sub-questions follow, typically [3][3][3][3][4]. The pattern in recent papers: (i) what has just happened or what the speaker means; (ii) explain a phrase or give what happened earlier; (iii) explain the speaker's method or the meaning of a passage; (iv) what happens next or why a character acts as they do; (v) a judgement question ('Which argument had the greatest impact? Give a reason') that asks for your view, supported from the text. For every sub-part: answer the question asked, quote two to five words, explain, and add the point about character or theme. A 3-mark part needs about three distinct points in four to six lines.

WEAK ANSWER Weak answer to 'Why does Brutus allow Antony to speak at the funeral?'

Brutus allows Antony to speak because he is honourable and trusts Antony. Cassius does not want it. Antony speaks and the crowd turns against Brutus. This was a big mistake.

EXCELLENT ANSWER Excellent answer to the same question

Brutus allows Antony to speak because he believes the people can be governed by reason: he will go "into the pulpit first / And show the reason of our Caesar's death", and Antony will speak "by leave and by permission", forbidden to "blame us". He thinks the gesture of allowing Caesar "all true rites and lawful ceremonies" will "advantage more than do us wrong", because it displays the conspirators' fairness. The decision flows from the same idealism as "sacrificers, but not butchers": Brutus wants the killing to look just. Cassius sees the danger ("Know you how much the people may be moved / By that which he will utter?") but is overruled, as he was over the oath and over killing Antony. The mistake is therefore not carelessness but character: Brutus judges the crowd and Antony by his own honesty, and Shakespeare makes his honour the cause of his defeat.

Why the excellent answer earns marks: it gives the stated reason, quotes the conditions, connects the decision to Brutus's character across the play, uses Cassius as contrast, and ends with a judgement.

Practice Set 1 — Act 3 Scene 1

EXTRACT Extract

Caesar: *I could be well moved, if I were as you. / If I could pray to move, prayers would move me. / But I am constant as the Northern Star, / Of whose true fixed and resting quality / There is no fellow in the firmament. / The skies are painted with unnumbered sparks; / They are all fire, and every one doth shine. / But there's but one in all doth hold his place. / So in the world: 'tis furnished well with men, / And men are flesh and blood, and apprehensive. / Yet in the number I do know but one / That unassailable holds on his rank, / Unshaked of motion; and that I am he*

QUESTIONS Questions

- (i) Where are Caesar and the speakers at this moment? What request has just been made, and by whom? [3] (ii) Explain the comparison Caesar makes between himself and the Northern Star. What does it reveal about him? [3] (iii) What does Caesar say immediately after this speech when Cinna and Decius try to plead? What happens next? [3] (iv) Explain Brutus's words to the senators after the killing, "Ambition's debt is paid", and what Brutus asks the conspirators to do with Caesar's blood. [3] (v) In your view, does this speech make Caesar's death seem more deserved or less deserved? Give reasons from the extract and from the scene. [4]

MODEL ANSWER Model answers

(i) They are at the Capitol, where the Senate is sitting, on the Ides of March. Metellus Cimber has knelt before Caesar to beg for the repeal of his brother Publius Cimber's banishment, and Brutus and Cassius have joined him on their knees ("As low as to thy foot doth Cassius fall"). The kneeling is the conspirators' agreed pretext for surrounding Caesar before they strike. **Why this earns marks:** place, occasion, request, requester, and the hidden purpose, each in a phrase.

(ii) The Northern Star is the one star that never moves while all the others wheel around it. Caesar says that among the countless men of "flesh and blood", who can be moved by reason or pleading ("apprehensive"), he alone is "unassailable" and "Unshaken of motion". It reveals his pride in his own constancy and his belief that he stands above ordinary humanity, almost a god; it also reveals a ruler who refuses to be swayed by favour, which he presents as a virtue. The irony is that he claims permanence seconds before he falls. **Why this earns marks:** explains the image, applies it, gives the character point, and adds the irony.

(iii) When Cinna pleads, Caesar says "Hence. Wilt thou lift up Olympus?", comparing himself to the mountain of the gods that no man can move. When Decius pleads, he says "Doth not Brutus bootless kneel?", meaning that if even Brutus kneels in vain, no one else can hope to succeed. Casca then cries "Speak, hands, for me!" and stabs him; the others follow, and Brutus strikes last, drawing Caesar's "Et tu, Brutè?—Then fall, Caesar." **Why this earns marks:** both replies, both glossed, then the sequence of the murder in order with the correct first and last strikers.

(iv) "Ambition's debt is paid" means that Caesar's ambition was a debt that could only be settled by his death, and that it has now been settled: the people and senators need fear nothing more. Brutus then tells the conspirators to "Stoop, Romans, stoop, / And let us bathe our hands in Caesar's blood / Up to the elbows and besmear our swords", and to walk to the marketplace waving their "red weapons" and crying "Peace, freedom, and liberty!" He wants the killing to appear as a solemn public sacrifice rather than a murder, fulfilling his wish in Act 2 to be "sacrificers, but not butchers". **Why this earns marks:** meaning of the phrase, the exact instruction, and the purpose behind it with a cross-reference.

(v) The speech cuts both ways, and a strong answer says so. It makes the death seem more deserved because Caesar's arrogance is at its height: he compares himself to the one fixed star and to Olympus, treats senators as "spaniel fawning" dogs, and refuses mercy as a matter of personal glory, so the conspirators' fear of a king seems justified. Yet it also makes the death seem less deserved: Caesar is refusing to bend the law for his friends, which is a ruler's virtue, and he is surrounded by men who kneel to him in false humility while hiding daggers. Shakespeare deliberately gives him his proudest words last so that the audience feels both the justice and the horror of what follows. On balance the scene, rather than the speech, decides: the sight of the "butchers" bathing in blood and Antony's grief tilt the audience's sympathy back towards Caesar. **Why this earns marks:** a clear view, evidence for both sides, a reason for the final judgement, and awareness of the dramatist's design. Four marks need four distinct supported points.

Practice Set 2 — Act 3 Scene 2

EXTRACT Extract

Antony: *But here's a parchment with the seal of Caesar. / I found it in his closet. 'Tis his will. / Let but the commons hear this testament, / Which, pardon me, I do not mean to read, / And they would go and kiss dead Caesar's wounds / And dip their napkins in his sacred blood— / Yea, beg a hair of him for memory / And, dying, mention it within their wills, / Bequeathing it as a rich legacy / Unto their issue.*

QUESTIONS Questions

(i) Where is Antony speaking, and to whom? What has he said just before this about stirring the crowd to "mutiny and rage"? [3] (ii) What does Antony claim he will not do with the will? Why does he mention it at all? What is this technique called and how do the plebeians respond? [3] (iii) What three proofs has Antony already offered that Caesar was not ambitious? [3] (iv) What does Antony do with Caesar's mantle and body after this, and how does the crowd react? [3] (v) Antony says later, "I am no orator, as Brutus is". How far is this true? Support your view from both speeches. [4]

MODEL ANSWER Model answers

(i) Antony is speaking from the pulpit in the Forum, at Caesar's funeral, to the Roman plebeians, after Brutus has spoken and left. He has just said that if he wished "to stir / Your hearts and minds to mutiny and rage" he would wrong Brutus and Cassius, "Who, you all know, are honourable men", and that he would rather "wrong the dead" than "such honourable men". The denial is a cover: he is about to do exactly what he disclaims. **Why this earns marks:** place, audience, moment, the preceding words quoted, and their irony.

(ii) He claims he does "not mean to read" the will. He mentions it to make the crowd desire it: by describing how they would kiss Caesar's wounds and treasure "a hair of him" if they knew its contents, he tells them Caesar loved them without stating it. The technique is paralipsis (drawing attention to something by pretending to pass over it), and it is also a form of suspense. The plebeians respond at once: "We'll hear the will. Read it, Mark Antony" and "The will, the will!", so that Antony can later seem to read it only because they "compel" him. **Why this earns marks:** the claim, the purpose, the named device, the crowd's exact response, and the advantage Antony gains.

(iii) First, Caesar "brought many captives home to Rome, / Whose ransoms did the general coffers fill", enriching the state, not himself. Second, "When that the poor have cried, Caesar hath wept", and "Ambition should be made of sterner stuff". Third, at the Lupercal Antony "thrice presented him a kingly crown, / Which he did thrice refuse", so he asks, "Was this ambition?" After each proof he repeats that Brutus "is an honourable man", so that the praise turns to irony. **Why this earns marks:** three proofs, each quoted and explained, plus the structural point about the refrain.

(iv) Antony descends, makes the crowd form a ring, and shows them Caesar's torn mantle, recalling the evening Caesar first wore it after defeating the Nervii. He points to the rents made by Cassius, by "the envious Casca", and by "the well-belovèd Brutus", calling Brutus's stab "the most unkindest cut of all" because Caesar loved him. Then he uncovers the body: "Here is himself, marred as you see with traitors." The crowd cries "O piteous spectacle!", "O traitors, villains!" and "We will be revenged", and surges to "Burn! Fire! Kill!" until Antony holds them back to hear the will. **Why this earns marks:** the actions in order, the key quotations, the reason given for Brutus's wound, and the crowd's turn.

(v) The claim is false, and deliberately so. Antony is the greater orator of the two. Brutus's prose speech is a reasoned argument built on balanced antitheses ("not that I loved Caesar less, but that I loved Rome more") and rhetorical questions that shame dissent; it wins applause but asks the crowd to accept the charge of ambition on Brutus's honour alone. Antony's verse speech supplies what Brutus omitted: evidence (the ransoms, the tears, the crown), emotion (the pause while his "heart is in the coffin"), objects (the mantle, the body, the will), and a refrain that turns "honourable" into an insult. Calling himself "a plain blunt man" with "neither wit, nor words, nor worth" is itself a rhetorical device, false modesty that makes the crowd trust him more. The results prove the point: Brutus's crowd says "Let him be Caesar"; Antony's crowd burns the conspirators' houses. **Why this earns marks:** a firm judgement, comparison of both speeches with quotation, identification of the device in the claim itself, and the outcome as evidence.

Ten multiple-choice questions

1. Who strikes Caesar first? (a) Brutus (b) Cassius (c) Casca (d) Decius
2. "What touches us ourself shall be last served" is Caesar's reply to: (a) Artemidorus (b) the Soothsayer (c) Metellus (d) Popilius Lena

3. Caesar compares himself to: (a) a lion (b) the Northern Star (c) a Colossus (d) an eagle
4. Who draws Antony away from Caesar before the murder? (a) Cinna (b) Trebonius (c) Decius (d) Metellus
5. Who objects to Antony speaking at the funeral? (a) Casca (b) Cinna (c) Cassius (d) Brutus
6. Brutus's funeral speech is in: (a) rhymed verse (b) blank verse (c) prose (d) Latin
7. The crowd's response to Brutus includes: (a) "Let not a traitor live!" (b) "Let him be Caesar." (c) "Read the will!" (d) "Tear him to pieces!"
8. According to Antony, the first time Caesar wore the mantle was the day he overcame: (a) Pompey (b) the Gauls (c) the Nervii (d) the Parthians
9. Caesar's will leaves each citizen: (a) seventy drachmas (b) seventy-five drachmas (c) a hundred drachmas (d) an orchard
10. Cinna the poet is killed because: (a) he supported Caesar (b) he wrote bad verses (c) he shares a conspirator's name (d) he was a senator

Answers: 1 (c); 2 (a); 3 (b); 4 (b); 5 (c); 6 (c); 7 (b); 8 (c); 9 (b); 10 (c). Question 10 is a favourite trap: the crowd jokes about his verses, but they attack him for his name.

Common errors in Act 3 answers

- Saying Brutus strikes first. Casca does; Brutus strikes last.
- Saying Antony fled "in terror" and did not return. He fled, then sent a servant with a carefully worded message, then came himself.
- Writing that Antony "insults Brutus". He never does so directly; the attack is entirely by irony and evidence.
- Saying the murder takes place in the Senate House historically. SHAKESPEARE'S TEXT places it at the Capitol; HISTORICAL RECORD places it in the Curia of Pompey. In the play, write "the Capitol".
- Calling the funeral speeches "debates". They are consecutive orations; Brutus is absent during Antony's.
- Writing 'the most unkind cut'. The text has "the most unkindest cut of all".
- Confusing the two Cinnas, and confusing the two Brutuses (Decius Brutus is a conspirator; Marcus Brutus is the leader).
- Treating "Et tu, Brutè?" as Plutarch. It is Shakespeare's inheritance from English tradition, not the ancient sources.

REVISION ONE-MINUTE REVISION — Act 3

Five events: Caesar refuses Cimber and is killed; Brutus's blood ritual and promise to Antony; Antony's handshake, request and prophecy; Brutus's speech then Antony's speech; the riot and the killing of Cinna the poet. **Five words:** Northern Star; Et tu, Brutè; honourable man; the will; Havoc. **Three quotations:** "I am constant as the Northern Star"; "not that I loved Caesar less, but that I loved Rome more."; "Friends, Romans, countrymen, lend me your ears." **Three character points:** Caesar is most godlike at the moment of death; Brutus's honour decides every mistake; Antony's grief and his cunning are the same force. **Three themes:** rhetoric and the crowd; honour versus judgement; pride and fate. **Two devices:** repetition turned to irony ("honourable men"); dramatic irony ("The ides of March are come"). **Two historical points:** Plutarch records the funeral and the will; the Latin "Et tu, Brutè" and the Capitol setting are Shakespeare's. **Three connections:** Calpurnia's dream → the hands bathed in blood; Cassius's wish to kill Antony → Antony's speech; the fickle crowd of Act 1 → the mob of Act 3. **One central idea:** the conspirators kill a man and leave his meaning alive; Antony picks it up and uses it.